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# THE SOCIAL MEDIA PLAYBOOK FOR CEOs: HOW TO USE TRANSFORMATIONAL LEADERSHIP-ORIENTED LANGUAGE ON SOCIAL MEDIA SUCCESSFULLY

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Research on CEOs' social media communication as a leadership instrument remains scarce. The current study addresses this gap by exploring the relationship between CEOs' leadership-oriented language and user engagement (i.e., sharing behavior). Based on an automated text analysis of 24,719 posts from 172 CEOs of Global *Fortune* 500 companies on X, one of the largest social media platforms previously known as Twitter, this research examines how CEOs' leadership-oriented lan-

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guage influences users' sharing behavior. In particular, it focuses on transformational leadership (TFL), a crucial approach in social media contexts. Utilizing hierarchical linear modeling, the findings revealed that CEOs' use of linguistic indicators reflecting TFL affects users' sharing behavior in partially unexpected and contradictory ways. Specifically, using positive emotional language and exclusive words in social media posts can diminish users' sharing behavior. Conversely, content-rich posts, replies that open a dialogic loop, and posts reflecting psychological closeness all positively influence users' sharing behavior. These findings underscore the complex nature of leadership-oriented language and provide novel insights into its effectiveness on social media. The current study offers specific guidelines for how CEOs can effectively utilize TFL-oriented language to engage their audiences while minimizing the risk of unintended negative consequences.

## Introduction

More than 80% of top executives regard social media as relevant for building and maintaining relationships with key stakeholders such as customers, employees, and investors (Mudambi et al., 2019). For chief executive officers (CEOs), social media can provide a platform to function as chief engagement officers (Yue et al., 2021), social CEOs (Craig & Amernic, 2020), inspirational leaders (Mudambi et al., 2019), or corporate ambassadors (Wu et al., 2022). The CEO's role in engaging the public represents an emerging research domain (Wu et al., 2025). A key decision for CEOs posting content on social media is about what and how to communicate. Research has investigated optimal communication for other key actors on social media, such as brand marketers (Labrecque et al., 2020), but the CEO is a unique type of leader who likely requires unique communication to foster broad engagement. Such communication can greatly impact the organization and the CEO's reputation (Craig & Amernic, 2020). However, existing research remains limited, as reflected by several recent calls for further research (e.g., Behrend et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2023).

Engagement is a key outcome of organizational activities on social media, with social media defined as any platform that facilitates user-generated content and real-time peer-to-peer interaction (Lin et al., 2021). Examples include the world's popular social networks X, Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok. For those posting on social media, from an organizational perspective, there are significant variations in engagement rates (Harrigan et al., 2021). Given that social media is a freely available resource for managers and leaders, it is important for them to understand how their communication drives such engagement (Villarroel Ordenes et al., 2019). More precisely, a primary goal in social media communication is reach; that is, aiming for one's message to be delivered to as wide an audience as possible (Villarroel Ordenes et al., 2019). For CEOs, such reach relies on the extent to which other users share their posts. Such virality, through sharing, is likely to result in higher visibility, even influence, for the CEO (Tur et al., 2022). However, there is still limited research on the specific drivers of social media content sharing and even less research on why CEOs' posts are likely to be shared (Tur et al., 2022). Research (e.g., Tur et al., 2022) has highlighted that users only share a post when convinced or influenced by it. Thus, sharing is particularly relevant to CEOs who, as leaders, often try to convince and influence. Consequently, the current study aimed to offer insights into whether and how CEOs' communication linked to leadership-oriented language might determine such leadership influence on social media.

Leadership can occur in formal settings, where a designated leader has explicit authority over followers, or in informal settings, where leaders "signal their beliefs and preferences to others but have no formal authority over them" (Tur et al., 2022, p. 3). Although no direct hierarchy exists on social media, some individuals emerge as leaders and influence others through the content they post and share (Tur et al., 2022). Thus, CEOs are formal leaders of



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their organizations, but they also have the potential to act as informal leaders in social media settings. This provides CEOs with the opportunity to interact with and exert influence on a variety of individuals (i.e., users). These users can be considered "diffused," as their relationships with the organization are less clear or formal in this specific context (Steinbach et al., 2021), implying a one-to-many leader–follower perspective (Matthews et al., 2022). This informal social media environment offers a unique opportunity to examine leadership as a purer form of social influence, since there is no formal hierarchy and participation is voluntary (Banks et al., 2022).

In the leadership domain, an approach that can be effective in inspiring and convincing followers in both formal and informal settings is transformational leadership (TFL) (Bass, 1999). TFL, due to its strong focus on inspiration, may be particularly suited to social media as an informal leadership setting. However, research on the influence of TFL-oriented language in informal, digital communication settings, such as social media, is still rare, which is evident in recent research calls (e.g., Matthews et al., 2022). Thus, the current study aimed to investigate CEOs' communication linked to TFL-oriented language on social media by performing an automated text analysis of 24,719 posts on X by 172 CEOs of Global *Fortune* 500 companies. These insights aimed to inform future decision-making among CEOs on how to effectively communicate on social media to drive user engagement. Because X is language-based, Becker et al.'s (2022) language-based operationalization of TFL with six linguistic indicators was used. Noting the hierarchical nature of the data set, hierarchical linear modeling (HLM) was used to assess the distinct impacts of the linguistic indicators that constitute TFL-oriented language on users' sharing behavior, which represents the highest level of engagement on social media platforms (Labrecque et al., 2020).

## CEOs' Communication and Users' Sharing Behavior on Social Media

For CEOs, social media offer strategic options to share information, align with stakeholders, shape organizational culture, and enhance perceptions of the organization's reputation, business model, or innovation (Conte et al., 2017). In fast-paced business environments, social media allows CEOs to communicate directly and immediately with large audiences, including customers, employees, and investors (Craig & Amernic, 2020). CEOs can also use social media for self-promotion and personal branding, framing their own narrative and signaling unobservable attributes like priorities or ideologies (Matthews et al., 2022). Moreover, CEOs utilize social media to establish thought leadership, a form of opinion leadership, by conveying expertise, which enhances their perceived credibility and is positively received by the public (Huang & Yeo, 2018). Overall, the research stream outlines *why* CEOs use social media. Another research stream concentrates on *what* CEOs decide to communicate on social media, often using content analyses. For example, Ingerson and Bruce (2013) demonstrated that CEOs not only offer business-related news but also share insights into their private lives. Research (e.g., La Bella et al., 2018; Porter et al., 2015) also exists on *how* CEOs communicate (i.e., communication style) on social media. For example, some CEOs use more formal language than general social media users (Porter et al., 2015).

On social media, a key outcome is engagement (Viglia et al., 2018). From a behavioral perspective, *engagement* is an actor's voluntary resource contributions that focus on the engagement object and occur in interactions with a focus object and/or other actors (Alexander et al., 2018). Such behaviors span a continuum, ranging from basic to advanced, including actions like liking, commenting, and sharing (Labrecque et al., 2020). Accordingly, CEOs can leverage social media to encourage a wide range of users to engage with their content to varying extents, such as by liking, replying (i.e., commenting), and sharing (i.e., reposting or retweeting) (Labrecque et al., 2020). Sharing a post represents the highest level of engagement behavior; it is a signal of endorsement where users typically only share a post if they have been inspired or convinced by it (Tur et al., 2022). When sharing a post, a user takes partial or full ownership of the original post, with the associated short- and long-term reputational risks (Labrecque et al., 2020). Users' sharing behavior is an important outcome for CEOs, as they



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want to reach as many users as possible to fulfill their corresponding intentions with the posts through high visibility (Lovelace et al., 2022). To achieve reach, their posts need to be inspiring or convincing, as evidenced when users share a post (Tur et al., 2022). Moreover, CEOs directly reveal to which extent users engage with their communication efforts, enabling them to update their communication accordingly.

Although studies have investigated CEOs' communication and users' sharing behavior on social media (e.g., Huang & Yeo, 2018; Men et al., 2018; Yue et al., 2019, 2023), there is no link to leadership-oriented communication. One exception is the research from Tur et al. (2022) who studied the impact of CEOs' communication linked to charismatic leadership language on users' sharing behavior. Thus, literature lacks comprehensive knowledge on understanding other established leadership approaches in informal settings (Matthews et al., 2022). Against this background, studying TFL-oriented language in social media contexts is particularly relevant, as TFL is one of the few leadership approaches that explicitly emphasizes inspiration (Bass, 1999; Ng, 2017). In social media settings, TFL may manifest as thought leadership, where CEOs engage and influence their audience by sharing visionary ideas and expertise. However, research remains scarce on whether and how CEOs' TFL-oriented language effectively drives engagement on social media. This study addressed this gap by examining the impact of CEOs' TFL-oriented language on user engagement.

## Transformational Leadership

The current study drew on TFL as a conceptual foundation to examine how CEOs' leadership-oriented language influences user engagement on social media. TFL encompasses three behavioral dimensions: charisma (comprising idealized influence and inspirational motivation), intellectual stimulation, and individualized consideration (Tims et al., 2011). Charisma is demonstrated when a leader envisions an appealing future, clearly outlines the path to achieve it, sets a personal example, establishes high-performance standards, and exhibits determination and confidence (Bass, 1999). Intellectual stimulation is displayed by leaders who encourage followers to think creatively and innovatively, challenge prior work assumptions, take risks by trying new things, and approach challenges in new ways, which entails issuing cognitive challenges to followers (Avolio et al., 1999). Finally, individualized consideration refers to paying close attention to followers' needs and concerns, as well as fostering each follower's development and growth (Bass, 1999).

## Relationship Between CEOs' Transformational Leadership-Oriented Language and Users' Sharing Behavior

### CHARISMA

Charismatic leaders communicate an inspiring vision (Alegbeleye & Kaufman, 2020), motivating followers emotionally (Tims et al., 2011). Their use of emotional, inspiring language helps them effectively convey a vision, encouraging followers to share their optimism and enthusiasm (Bono & Judge, 2004). Charismatic leaders' positive emotional expressions influence followers by transmitting positive emotions, which motivate followers to make greater personal efforts toward achieving the leader's well-articulated vision (Bono & Judge, 2004; Kopperud et al., 2014). On social media, posts containing *positive emotions* are more likely to be shared through emotional contagion (Akpinar & Berger, 2017), making users feel good and motivating them to share content for self-enhancement and to encourage future interactions (Tellis et al., 2019). Thus, the current study assumed that CEOs exerting charisma on social media encourage users to share posts when they communicate their appealing and persuasive vision using positive emotional language in their posts.

Furthermore, charismatic leaders articulate clear, vivid visions, creating concrete images for followers, akin to a "verbal portrait" (Carton et al., 2014), that appear personally relevant and immediate to them (Becker et al., 2022). Consequently, followers' perceptions of the vision's meaningfulness and identification with it increase (Horstmeier et al., 2017). Users can develop concrete representations of a topic, object, or event when the language used in a social media post displays



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a low *psychological distance* (i.e., psychological closeness) (Lim et al., 2012). Psychological distance is defined as an individual's perceptions of when, where, to whom, and whether an event occurs (Trope & Liberman, 2010). A psychologically proximal event usually gets formulated concretely, with a focus on details, and is perceived as immediate, highly visible, relevant, and salient (Hanks et al., 2020). Therefore, the current study assumed that CEOs who exhibit charisma can further drive users' sharing behavior by using language that conveys psychological closeness, making their vision feel urgent, relevant, and worthy of immediate action.

Overall, these considerations suggest that CEOs' social media posts, which reflect charisma, may influence users' sharing behavior. Specifically, the current study hypothesized that CEOs' social media posts reflecting charisma, by using (a) positive emotional language and (b) language mirroring psychological closeness, would relate positively to users' sharing behavior (Hypothesis 1).

## INTELLECTUAL STIMULATION

Intellectual stimulation encourages people to reexamine their assumptions and challenge traditional ways of doing things, implying notable demands on cognitive resources (Diebig et al., 2016). To encourage followers to challenge their perspectives (Tims et al., 2011), leaders put on an air of questioning the status quo and use a challenging tone (Boies et al., 2015). Grammatical complexity in written statements, such as exclusive words, indicates transformational leaders' ability to express themselves clearly and get followers to challenge their assumptions or review problems from different angles (Balthazard et al., 2009). Few studies have addressed *exclusive words* in social media contexts, except when detailing deceptive speech (e.g., fake news and misinformation). For example, conspiracy theorists on X tend to write in a less complex way, using fewer words, to avoid imposing high cognitive loads on recipients (Visentin et al., 2021). In contrast, the current study assumed that CEOs who decide to frame their social media posts more complexly, aiming to stimulate users cognitively, would increase users' interest in the post.

Intellectually stimulating leaders are also characterized by their language complexity (Boies et al., 2015). Language complexity increases with *more words* (Di Domenico et al., 2021). Regarding social media, longer, more complex posts with more words, which imply greater content richness, evoke more sharing (Xu & Zhang, 2018). Thus, the current study proposes that CEOs who decide to frame their social media posts more complexly evoke intellectual stimulation by increasing users' interest in the post, which encourages users to share it.

Building on this line of reasoning, it can be assumed that CEOs' social media posts reflecting intellectual stimulation foster users' willingness to share content. Specifically, the current study hypothesized that CEOs' social media posts reflecting intellectual stimulation, by using (a) exclusive words and (b) more words, would relate positively to users' sharing behavior (Hypothesis 2).

## INDIVIDUALIZED CONSIDERATION

Individualized consideration signals genuine attention to each follower's needs, feelings, and skill development, adjusting communication accordingly (Berson & Avolio, 2004). Consequently, followers feel a sense of belonging and identification with the leader (Horstmeier et al., 2017). Followers respond by putting more effort into their work to reciprocate the leader's care and recognition, attributable to social exchange principles (Ghadi et al., 2013). Such feelings of duty or responsibility result in close relationships between leaders and followers (Duan et al., 2022). On social media, a dialogic loop (e.g., *reacting to users' comments*) significantly enhances users' sharing behavior, as users feel a strong social presence (Men et al., 2018). They also perceive the virtual interaction as similar to a face-to-face interaction, resulting in positive attitudes toward the interaction partner (Song et al., 2019). Also, users expect CEOs to interact directly with them and acknowledge their opinions, ideas, and suggestions, or even ask directly for their ideas and opinions (Berson & Avolio, 2004).

Leaders' involvement in dialogic principles is another important linguistic feature of individual consideration. On social media, using *second-person pronouns* is identified as a dialogic principle, as it initiates dialogue by directly addressing the reader



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(Labrecque et al., 2020) and emphasizes the individual by directing attention to the user and creating a sense of personalization (Cruz et al., 2017). Thus, second-person pronouns on social media can increase connections with users, enhancing the likelihood of sharing posts (Cruz et al., 2017). The current study assumed that CEOs who signal individual consideration by establishing reciprocal relationships and using second-person pronouns encourage users' sharing behavior. Such posts directly address users and their needs and offer strong potential for dialogic communication. Personalization also motivates users to share content that triggers their sense of identification and obligation.

Taken together, the foregoing arguments suggest that CEOs' social media posts, which reflect individualized consideration, promote users' sharing behavior. Based on this reasoning, the current study hypothesized that CEOs' social media posts reflecting individualized consideration, by (a) replying directly to users and (b) using second-person pronouns, would relate positively to users' sharing behavior (Hypothesis 3).

## Methods

### RESEARCH SETTING AND PROCEDURE

The current study employed HLM to test the hypotheses and, thus, produce knowledge on the impact of TFL-oriented language on user engagement. X, one of the most popular social media platforms (Wu et al., 2025), served as the study context. In 2023, X had over 415 million users who spent 5.3 hours per month on the platform (Statista, 2023). Statistics from 2022 showed that 59% of users in the United States regularly get their news from X (Statista, 2023). Despite some recent upheaval and controversies, following a takeover, X is likely to remain a prominent social media platform and an important social media channel for organization- and brand-related communication (Wu et al., 2022). X also has frequently served as an academic test bed and is the most widely used platform for research into leadership behavior (Matthews et al., 2022).

To collect posts by CEOs of the Global *Fortune* 500 companies, a list of the companies and their CEOs over the period 2016–2021 was composed and determined which of the CEOs had accounts on X, followed by collecting their official handles. For example, Tim Cook, CEO of Apple, uses @tim_cook. Next, the history of CEO posts in English and their corresponding sharing metrics was queried. 24,719 original posts posted by 172 CEOs of Global *Fortune* 500 companies on X were obtained.

### DATA AND MEASURES

#### Writing Style Extraction

To extract the TFL dimensions from the posts, Linguistic Inquiry and Word Count (LIWC), an automated text analysis software (Boyd et al., 2022), was used. LIWC compares each post with a categorized dictionary of words to produce the percentage of words belonging to a specific category. The dictionary is predefined, so no additional learning is needed to extract linguistic markers. The validity and reliability of LIWC have been confirmed, and extant literature (e.g., Becker et al., 2022; Boyd et al., 2022) has indicated respectable agreement between extracted LIWC constructs and human coders' annotations. It is an easy-to-use and popular academic tool for extracting psychological and linguistic constructs from textual content, frequently used in top-tier journals (Kim et al., 2019; Ludwig et al., 2014). Moreover, it has been previously used to extract TFL-oriented language from text (Becker et al., 2022).

#### Dependent Variable

Users' sharing behavior reflects the strongest engagement behavior on social media (Tur et al., 2022; Villarroel Ordenes et al., 2019). Therefore, the current study concentrated on the number of shares a CEO post received. The mean and standard deviation of the number of shares were 845.957 and 5,659.180, respectively.

#### Independent Variables

To operationalize the dimensions of TFL, the current study used the operationalization by Becker et al. (2022). First, charisma was measured with two linguistic indicators: positive emotional language and psychological distance. The positive emotional language LIWC category, *emo_pos*, extracts the percentage of positive emotions (e.g., good, love, happy, hope) in the CEO post. A greater degree of positive emotional language implies



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more charismatic language use. Psychological distance, versus psychological closeness, in a particular CEO post was measured by using a factor-analysis derived construct variable developed by Cohn et al. (2004). Specifically, LIWC scores for articles (*article*) and long words (*bigwords*), along with inverse scores for first-person singular pronouns (*ipron*), terms that indicate discrepancy from reality (e.g., would, can, and could) (*discrep*), and present-tense verbs (*focuspresent*) were used. CEOs' closeness in the posts was measured in a reversed way; low values signal experiential and personal language focusing on reality and thus result in greater charisma, whereas high values represent rational, impersonal, and abstract tones with thus lower levels of charisma.

Second, for intellectual stimulation, exclusive words and the number of words in the post were measured. The *differ* LIWC category (e.g., but, not, if, and or) assesses exclusivity, such that the greater the percentage of words in the *differ* category, the higher the intellectual stimulation. The post's length, measured in number of words, also indicates intellectual stimulation. The longer the post, the higher the level of intellectual stimulation.

Third, two variables were used to gauge individualized consideration: the number of replies and second-person pronouns. Establishing reciprocal relationships is an element of individualized consideration. Thus, the intensity of the relationship between the CEO and users was measured based on the number of replies. Second-person pronouns in LIWC were operationalized by the category "*you*." When a CEO addresses others directly with second-person pronouns in a post, it creates a sense of personalization. Therefore, more second-person pronouns signal more individualized consideration.

### Control Variables

In addition to the TFL-oriented independent variables, a variety of control variables were included. First, *post tag variables* indicated the number of mentions, hashtags, and URLs, which appear to have relationships with the number of shares (Harrigan et al., 2021). Second, the *type of post* was added as a control variable, namely, whether the CEO posts a non-referenced post, a quoted post, or a reply. Third, *time variables* (Rooderkerk & Pauwels, 2016) offered dummy measures of weekends or weekdays, seasons (winter, summer, spring, and autumn), time of day (afternoon, evening, morning, and night), and the year of posting (2016 through 2021).

### DATA ANALYSIS

The study setup showed a hierarchical structure as multiple posts are nested within each CEO. Therefore, HLM was used to estimate the nested relationship between the TFL independent variables on the one hand and the users' sharing behavior by means of the number of shares on the other hand (Hox et al., 2018). This is necessary because TFL-oriented language characteristics of the posts from the same CEO should generally be more similar than those of posts by different CEOs. An intercept model including independent and control variables was estimated. The study relied on restricted maximum likelihood estimation (Kenward & Roger, 2009). A completely unstructured covariance matrix avoided additional constraints during the estimation procedure. Log-transforming the dependent variable accounted for skewness; the independent and control variables were standardized. The HLM did not suffer from multicollinearity issues, as the correlation matrix in Table 1 reveals, and in view of the low variance inflation factor scores (maximum = 1.67).

## Results

### CHARISMA

Positive emotional language had a significant negative effect on users' sharing behavior ($\beta = -.032$, $p < .01$; see Table 2). The more positive emotional language expressed in CEOs' posts, the lower the sharing behavior. Psychological distance had a significant negative influence on users' sharing behavior ($\beta = -.108$, $p < .01$), reflecting that experiential and personal language use (i.e., psychological closeness) had a positive influence on the number of shares a post gets. Therefore, the results did not support H1a, as the results revealed an inverse significant support, while supporting H1b.



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**Table 1 Means, Standard Deviations, and Correlation Matrix**

| | | Mean | SD | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Positive emotional language | 1.833 | 4.047 | | | | | | |
| 2 | Psychological distance | .000 | 1.000 | .060 | | | | | |
| 3 | Exclusive words | 1.699 | 3.539 | −.090 | −.182 | | | | |
| 4 | Word count | 23.681 | 13.42 | −.079 | −.505 | .036 | | | |
| 5 | Number of replies | 704.237 | 976.272 | −.075 | .124 | .158 | −.424 | | |
| 6 | Second-person pronouns | 1.028 | 3.103 | .087 | −.031 | −.009 | −.054 | −.049 | |
| 7 | Number of shares | 845.947 | 5,659.180 | −.013 | −.009 | .001 | −.088 | .150 | .008 |

### INTELLECTUAL STIMULATION

The number of exclusive words used by the CEO exerted a significant negative impact on users' sharing behavior ($\beta = -.027$, $p < .01$); the average word count per post had a significant positive effect ($\beta = .202$, $p < .01$). Thus, the results revealed an inverse significant support for H2a, while H2b was supported.

### INDIVIDUALIZED CONSIDERATION

The number of replies was positively related to users' sharing behavior ($\beta = 2.316$, $p < .01$), while second-person pronouns had no significant impact ($\beta = -.001$, n.s.). Therefore, H3a was supported, while there was no support for H3b.

### CONTROL VARIABLES

The number of mentions had a significant negative impact on users' sharing behavior ($\beta = -.199$, $p < .01$), in contrast with the number of hashtags, which had a significant positive impact ($\beta = .022$, $p < .05$). The number of URLs had no impact ($\beta = .037$, n.s.). Furthermore, the post type exerted a significant impact on users' sharing behavior, such that quoted posts ($\beta = -.516$, $p < .01$) and replied posts ($\beta = -2.652$, $p < .01$) by CEOs had less impact on users' sharing behavior than a non-referenced post. Finally, the time-related control variables (i.e., weekend, season (except for morning), daytime, and year) did not impact users' sharing behavior.

## Discussion

The six linguistic indicators reflecting the three TFL dimensions affected users' sharing behavior somewhat unexpectedly. As hypothesized and consistent with other social media studies without a leadership focus (e.g., Lim et al., 2012), CEOs' posts reflecting psychological distance, mirroring low levels of charisma, were shared less. Thus, CEOs' posts characterized by psychological closeness seem to boost users' perceptions of the meaningfulness of the post. Surprisingly, the findings showed that when CEOs' social media posts contain a high percentage of positive emotions (e.g., words such as good, love, and happy), users share them less. Empirical evidence suggests that negative sentiment garners increased attention on social media, a phenomenon known as negativity bias (Vaish et al., 2008). Negative sentiment is identified as a critical trigger of virality, resulting in more shares (Sangiorgio et al., 2025; Watson et al., 2024). On X, negative emotions are especially prevalent and accepted (Waterloo et al., 2018). This may cause users to avoid sharing positively framed posts due to emotional incongruence; the mismatch between a post filled with positive emotions and the platform's negative emotional climate could diminish users' willingness to engage. Thus, sharing positive-filled messages might depend on the social media platform; an observation that is similar to existing research (e.g., Villarroel Ordenes et al., 2019) highlighting that positively framed messages enhanced sharing on Facebook, but not on X.

Furthermore, CEOs' social media posts reflecting intellectual stimulation by using more words per post related positively to users' sharing behavior, consistent with previous social media literature without a leadership focus (e.g., Di Domenico et al., 2021). However, research (e.g., Meire et al., 2022) on the complexity of social media posts (i.e., readability) demon-



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**Table 2 HLM Analysis Results**

| | | Variable | | Users' Sharing Behavior |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Transformational leadership dimensions | Charisma | Positive emotional language | | –.032 (–4.24)** |
| | | Psychological distance | | –.108 (–11.93)** |
| | Intellectual stimulation | Exclusive words | | –.027 (–3.48)** |
| | | Word count | | .202 (17.16)** |
| | Individualized consideration | Number of replies | | 2.316 (6.37)** |
| | | Second-person pronouns | | –.001 (–.10) |
| Control variables | Post tags | Number of mentions | | –.199 (–34.10)** |
| | | Number of hashtags | | .022 (2.10)* |
| | | Number of URLs | | .037 (1.83) |
| | Type of post | Dummy type | Quoted | –.516 (–22.10)** |
| | | | Reply | –2.652 (–94.56)** |
| | | | None | . |
| | Time | Dummy weekend | Yes | –.008 (–.46) |
| | | Dummy season | Winter | .037 (1.75) |
| | | | Spring | .022 (1.07) |
| | | | Summer | –.012 (–.56) |
| | | | Autumn | . |
| | | Dummy daytime | Morning | .086 (3.25)** |
| | | | Afternoon | –.011 (–.49) |
| | | | Evening | –.008 (–.37) |
| | | | Night | . |
| | | Dummy year | 2016 | .883 (1.49) |
| | | | 2017 | .875 (1.55) |
| | | | 2018 | .800 (1.43) |
| | | | 2019 | .554 (1.01) |
| | | | 2020 | .577 (1.07) |
| | | | 2021 | . |
| | | Number of posts | 24,719 | |
| | | Number of CEOs | 172 | |
| | | –2 residual log likelihood | 77,223.04 | |

*Note.* Standardized estimates with *t*-values in parentheses are reported.
*$p<.05$;
**$p<.01$.

strated that less readable messages (i.e., high message complexity) tend to generate lower engagement on social media. However, our findings indicated that a certain level of complexity, reflected in using more words, is associated with increased engagement. These seemingly contrasting findings suggest the potential presence of a quadratic relationship, which future research should explore in greater depth. Nevertheless, the findings showed that users were interested in content-rich CEO posts that intellectually stimulated them, though not by using exclusive words, which were negatively related to users' sharing behavior. Exclusive words might be perceived as opinionated, discursive (e.g., words such as "however" and "but"), or ambiguous (e.g., words such as "or"). Thus, sharing might be less likely.

Finally, CEOs' social media posts reflecting individualized consideration by replying directly to users



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related positively to users' sharing behavior, in line with previous findings in social media studies (e.g., Men et al., 2018). However, the findings showed that CEOs' posts reflecting individual consideration by using second-person pronouns did not significantly influence users' sharing behavior. Closer consideration of the collected posts revealed that CEOs who use second-person pronouns usually personally address a specific individual (e.g., another CEO and politician) or group (e.g., employees and first responders). Such posts did not refer to a broad community; thus, they might not boost users' general sharing behavior. Consequently, users might not be personally attached to the CEOs' posts, mirroring individualized consideration. Even if users were addressed personally, they might open a dialogue in the comments rather than sharing; an explanation consistent with the results for the control variables: The more mentions a post contained, the less it was shared.

## THEORETICAL IMPLICATIONS

The current study goes beyond examining what CEOs communicate on social media to explore how their leadership-oriented language affects users' sharing behavior, uncovering some surprisingly ambivalent impact patterns. Unlike previous studies, which mainly reported desirable or nonsignificant effects (e.g., Tur et al., 2022), the current study identified some unintended adverse effects of CEO communication characteristics linked to leadership-oriented language (i.e., TFL-oriented language). Thus, the current study revealed that leadership-oriented language does not always produce the intended outcomes. The current study extends the literature by showing that only specific linguistic indicators of TFL-oriented language are effective for CEOs on social media, likely due to platform-specific factors such as negativity bias. Such an insight underscores the need to consider the specifics of different leadership contexts that influence the effectiveness of deploying a specific leadership language approach.

Second, the current study responds to various calls (e.g., Heavey et al., 2020; Legutko, 2020; Matthews et al., 2022) for testing existing leadership theories in social media contexts, where leadership research remains limited (e.g., Behrend et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2023). Big data techniques were applied to analyze thousands of posts from CEOs of Global *Fortune* 500 companies and their communication linked to leadership-oriented language (i.e., TFL-oriented language), yet with partially divergent results. Thus, treating the linguistic indicators as independent factors better reflects the different facets of TFL by capturing fine nuances within each TFL dimension. This challenges a common approach to measuring TFL with a single scale score (Hughes et al., 2018). Therefore, the current study extends the literature by showing that various linguistic indicators are useful for studying CEOs' communication linked to TFL-oriented language on social media.

Third, questions of if and how a single person can influence many different users simultaneously have remained unanswered (Liu et al., 2023; Roccapriore & Pollock, 2023), because prior research focused primarily on the dyad level (e.g., leader–employee, and employee–employee) or team level (e.g., leader–team). Thus, drawing on social media as an informal leadership context without formal authority, the current study illustrates ways to exert online influence on diverse audiences by evoking users' sharing behavior. Such a broader view clarifies potential individual influences on various audiences simultaneously, such as employees, shareholders, or suppliers, not all of whom have a formal relationship with the company.

## PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

In line with a recent call for evidence-based guidelines for CEOs and their communication teams (Yue et al., 2021), the findings provide several practical suggestions. Specifically, CEOs should be careful with using positive emotional language; instead, they should post in a personally attached, vivid, experiential, and immediate manner to reflect psychological closeness. It is also important for CEOs to foster intellectual stimulation by using more words. Although the number of words indicates content-rich posts, which stimulate users intellectually, exclusive words (e.g., but, however, or) represent disagreement, opposition, or ambiguity, which might negatively influence attitudes toward the CEO's



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post. This might result in decreased sharing behavior among users. Finally, CEOs should reply to users whenever appropriate and feasible. Such behavior has the potential to positively influence users' sharing behavior significantly, whereas personally addressing users with second-person pronouns does not help increase users' sharing behavior. Thus, when replying to a user's post, a broad answer to a question or issue tends to prompt more shares, compared with a post personally addressed only to an individual user. In terms of the controls, a single replied or quoted post (i.e., post-level) is less influential, but many replies in total (i.e., on CEO (person)-level) increase users' sharing behavior. Thus, especially if CEOs are not able or willing to put much effort into social media communication, they should avoid single-quoted posts and single replies. If they are eager to put more effort into social media communication, CEOs should intensify reciprocal relationships with users by replying to posts on the person-level.

## LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

Several limitations of this study point to suggestions for future research. First, this study focused on CEOs' communication on one social media platform (i.e., X). This single-platform design limits the generalizability of the findings, as communication norms and user engagement may differ across platforms (Villarroel Ordenes et al., 2019). Accordingly, investigating CEOs' communication linked to leadership-oriented language (i.e., TFL-oriented language) on social media platforms other than X, such as LinkedIn or Threads, could reveal whether and when they are suitable in other informal leadership settings. Furthermore, examining multiple platforms would allow for investigating potential spillover effects between social media platforms and even other communication channels such as email. This consideration extends beyond public platforms to include other work-related communication channels. In this context, future research could provide valuable insights into this phenomenon, aligning with Behrend et al.'s (2024) recent call to explore how leaders' public and internal social media communications influence employees' perceptions and behavior.

Second, the current study relied on linguistic indicators of TFL, which, while grounded in theory and validated, capture only textual aspects of CEOs' leadership-oriented language. Future research could perform additional analyses, including tone and visuals, to provide a more comprehensive understanding of leadership-oriented language on social media. Additionally, other leadership approaches reflected in language might be interesting to study. Virtual communication in the Metaverse also requires consideration, as immersive formats may alter how leadership is perceived and acted upon. In this context, researchers should be able to measure CEOs' actual behavior directly, not only their language use, and determine the impact on followers' behavior. Researchers would thus be able to further test leadership theories and expand knowledge about their effectiveness in informal leadership settings.

Third, user engagement was operationalized solely as sharing behavior, which represents one facet of social media engagement. Future studies might extend this by analyzing additional forms of user engagement (e.g., comments, quotes). In particular, content analyses of users' responses could deepen understanding of why specific leadership-oriented language elicits sharing and how users interpret those messages. Further research might also shed light on possible mediation pathways (e.g., identification mechanism) by which leadership-oriented language engenders users' sharing behavior.

Finally, although key control variables were included (e.g., post tags, type, and posting time), other contextual and individual factors may influence the results. Specifically, future research should consider the frequency of posts (Wang et al., 2020), as a higher posting frequency by a CEO may intensify leaders' relationships developed with followers and enhance user engagement. This, in turn, could influence the dynamic between the CEO and users, ultimately shaping the CEO's influence on social media. Additionally, the timing of the post is another important control variable that needs further consideration, as research has demonstrated that most impressions occur shortly after posting (Pfeffer et al., 2023), potentially influencing a post's visibility and, consequently, user engagement. Finally, future research might control for CEO-related (e.g., popularity (Lovelace et al., 2022) or perceived humility (Men et al., 2018)) and company-related (e.g., company performance or crisis (Heavey et al., 2020)) factors, which



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could interact with CEOs' TFL-oriented language or directly impact user engagement.

## Conclusion

By identifying the elements of leadership-oriented language (i.e., TFL-oriented language) in CEOs' social media posts that lead to the highest engagement, the current study provides not only novel insights but also a foundation for continued research into how a single individual's leadership-oriented communication can appeal to a diverse audience.

## Author Contributions

**Ellen Weber:** Conceptualization; project administration; writing—original draft; writing—review and editing. **Kristof Coussement:** Conceptualization; data curation; formal analysis; investigation; methodology; software; validation; writing—original draft; writing—review and editing. **Marion Büttgen:** Conceptualization; writing—review and editing. **Paul Harrigan:** Conceptualization; writing—original draft; writing—review and editing.

## Data Availability Statement

To promote research transparency, the author team commits that the data, if necessary, could be made available on, for example, an online repository. Specifically, the following two data sources could be made available: (1) The entire list of X handles of all CEOs of the Global *Fortune* 500 companies considered in this paper and (2) the final dataset of CEOs' posts on X and corresponding users' sharing behavior, transformational leadership dimensions, and control variables. The provided data sets allow one to conduct the main tests reported in the paper. Moreover, we have presented the data collection procedures and the data analytic method we used in our study clearly and understandably.

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